

collaboration rooms to the catwalks of the fashion houses.

Other commercial telepresence systems

Cisco is not the only company that is implementing telepresence technologies. Some other notable products in this market are:

Giraffe video conferencing robot. HeadThere's Giraffe is a mobile robot that can be moved around its location by a remote control using the Internet. The Giraffe allows a user to hear, see and speak at a far away location, just like traditional videoconferencing. Because people near the robot can see and hear the user, they interact with him as if he was truly present. In a sense, the robot acts as a stand-in for the user.

MILO. MILO is one of the first commercially available telepresence robots. The company's early adoptors programme currently uses 15 robots to explore various applications within the telepresence space. These include elderly care, commercial security, pro-

cess automation, real-time inventory tracking and more.

TrueLook. TrueLook was produced by a company called Perceptual Robotics, Inc. (PRI) used the term 'telepresence' to describe its remote-controlled robotic webcams because of the 'sense of being there' that they provided. Later renamed TrueLook, the product still exists, although the company does not. PRI was sold to Divine, Inc. in 2002 and the TrueLook product was later acquired by Silk Road Technologies, where it remains available.

PEBBLES. PEBBLES is claimed by its developer, Telbotics, to be the world's first fully functioning telepresence application. Useful for hospitalised, homebound and special needs children, it is intended to connect children to their classroom, allowing participation in classroom activities and social contact.

RealPresence. Polycom claims that its RealPresence system offers high-definition video in cinematic view, stereo surround audio and high-

resolution content in an immersive telepresence environment.

Intercompany telepresence

Large consumer-goods manufacturers can use intercompany telepresence to collaborate regularly with their hundreds of suppliers, retailers and business partners in distributed global locations. The manufacturers can collaborate with retailers for promotions and product placement, and also with advertising partners for branding and ad campaigns. The value of intercompany telepresence—and the network service that makes it possible—is expected to increase in proportion to the square of the number of users.

As the telepresence technology aims at reducing the costs, this technology would certainly find its roots in the near future in numerous applications. ●

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